



Introduction

Interest in the concept of the **assemblage**, and by implication the work of Deleuze and Guattari, can be understood, I believe, as a critical response to the growing awareness at the turn of the last century of a new type of social and cultural problem which John Law aptly named ‘messy’.¹ ‘No doubt some things in the world can indeed be made clear and definite. Income distributions, global CO₂ emissions, the boundaries of nation states, and terms of trade, these are the kinds of provisionally stable realities that social and natural science deal with more or less effectively. But alongside such phenomena the world is also textured in quite different ways.’² Unhelpfully, Law tends to collapse all ‘non-definite’ problems into one ‘order’ of problem – namely the messy. He avers that ‘[p]ains and pleasures, hopes and horrors, intuitions and apprehensions, losses and redemptions, mundanities and visions, angels and demons, things that slip and slide, or appear and disappear, change shape or don’t have much form at all, unpredictabilities’ all fall outside of the range of what social science has traditionally been able to ‘capture’.³ He may well be right in saying this, but it doesn’t follow that all these examples can (much less should) be thought in the same way, using the same conceptual framework. If, as Deleuze says, we have the philosophy we deserve according to how well we formulate our problems, then it is important that we take the time to think in a clear and definite way about things

Order + mess

tendency to order + organize or otherwise create bounded knowledge in the social sciences

that are not themselves clear and definite. In that respect I do not see much advantage in terms like Morton's concept of 'mesh' or Ingold's 'assembly', both of which seem to me to push thinking towards the indefinite and undecided as the best we can hope for, thus making the end point of thinking identical to the starting point, which amounts to a defeat of thought. As Deleuze and Guattari say, 'If one concept is "better" than an earlier one, it is because it makes us aware of new variations and unknown resonances, it carries out unforeseen cuttings-out, it brings forth an Event that surveys us.'⁴ Our question should thus be: What does the concept of the assemblage enable us to see that we couldn't see before?

The answer to this question, which many commentators have put to themselves, is surprisingly uniform across the spectrum of responses. In large part, though, this is because so-called assemblage theory, rather than going to the original source, seems content to rely on a handful of commentaries on Deleuze and Guattari for their definition of the concept. Doubtless this is because the original source is complicated, to say the least, and far from easy to strip-mine for straightforward definitions. For example, DeLanda claims that Deleuze and Guattari give assemblage 'half a dozen different interpretations', which he professes to bring together in order to create a unified version of the concept. The trouble is, to do that he modifies the concept, introducing new ways of thinking about the assemblage which, on the one hand, he dismisses as 'harmless' additions and, on the other hand, extols as necessary changes to make the concept immune to certain logical difficulties that are, in DeLanda's view, inherent in Deleuze and Guattari's version of the concept.⁵ Simplifying Deleuze and Guattari's thought, as DeLanda tries to do, does not seem to me to be the right way of going about this because, apart from the strange model of scholarship it entails, of avoiding rather than working through conceptual difficulty, it

necessarily leads to a diminished understanding of the concept. And yet that tends to be the way most commentators go about dealing with the concept of the assemblage, which no doubt explains both the uniformity of interpretations and the apparent reluctance in the field to return to the original source material. Assemblage has all but become a 'received idea' (as Flaubert put it), that is, an idea that is so well understood it no longer bears thinking about in a critical way.

Accordingly, any *and* every 'thing', or more precisely, any and every kind of *collection of things* has in recent times been called an assemblage. And even more problematically the coming together of every kind of *collection of things* is now referred to as assembling, even though assemblage in Deleuze and Guattari's sense and assembling are not linguistically related and in fact derive from two different words. This constant and seemingly limitless expansion of the term's range of applications begs the question, ever more insistently it seems to me, if any and every kind of collection of things is an assemblage, then what advantage is there in using this term and not some other term, or indeed no term at all? What makes an assemblage an assemblage and not some other kind of collection of things? If any apparently random 'heap of fragments', to use Jameson's suggestive phrase for the 'randomly heterogeneous and fragmentary and the aleatory', is an assemblage then the concept serves only to say either that everything is more organized than it appears, or, on the contrary, that everything is ultimately less organized than it appears. Either the heap of fragments has a secret order we don't see or the apparently ordered totality is really a heap of fragments if only we knew how to look properly.⁶ Either way, it does not move us much beyond a highly ambivalent baseline assumption, and we surely have a right to expect more from a new concept. At stake here, I would argue, is the need to distinguish the adjectival from the analytical and to recognize that it is only the latter form that is properly philosophical. Our task here,

then, is to isolate and define the specifically Deleuze and Guattarian species of assemblage and evaluate it against other varieties on offer. More often than not this will entail an examination of the hybrids on offer and asking what is gained and what is lost in the changes enacted. For these reasons, and more that I will elaborate throughout this book, I argue that we need to *return to the work of Deleuze and Guattari* if we are to make full use of the concept of the assemblage.⁷

Although at its core assemblage theory clearly arose out of the work of Deleuze and Guattari, particularly *A Thousand Plateaus*, it does not always adhere to their conception of it; indeed, as I argue here, it frequently departs from their work in quite significant ways. Both Actor-Network Theory (ANT), which arose out of the work of Bruno Latour, and New Materialism, which arose out of the work of Manuel DeLanda, Jane Bennett and William Connolly (among others), are prime examples of bodies of work that fit the category of assemblage theory and acknowledge a debt to the work of Deleuze and Guattari but nonetheless go about things in their own way, often in ways that are at odds with the inspirational source. DeLanda admits as much when he offers the conceit that his work might be thought of as a kind of Deleuze 2.0. The difficulties don't stop there because there is also a considerable body of work that falls under the heading of assemblage theory that not only owes nothing at all to the work of Deleuze and Guattari but doesn't even bear a 'family resemblance' to their thinking as both ANT and New Materialism do. So while there can be no question that the concept of the assemblage has generated interesting new ways of thinking about the complex nature of social reality, in the evolutionary leap it made from being a concept confined to the work of Deleuze and Guattari to a global theory it has also drifted a long way from its origins and in doing so a number of both small and large misprisions of Deleuze and Guattari's work have slipped under the radar and embedded themselves as 'truths'.⁸ These misprisions are, in

some instances, of the order of Harold Bloom's notion of the strong misreading, they are the necessary condition of a certain kind of creative appropriation of Deleuze and Guattari's work, as one might claim is true of both Bruno Latour's and Manuel DeLanda's work, but as I will argue these versions of the assemblage are considerably narrower in scope than the version one finds in Deleuze and Guattari.

One may well answer this judgement by saying that Deleuze and Guattari do not themselves call for strict adherence to their ideas and this is certainly true. But Deleuze also said that his own appropriations of other philosophers, which he freely admitted were monstrous, were always true to their original authors. It was important to him that he didn't put words in their mouth, and that the child he made with them was unmistakably their offspring.⁹ It is my contention here that most of the existing appropriations of Deleuze and Guattari's work do not meet this standard and that this matters because the versions of assemblage theory they have given us are in several key ways inferior to the original, to the point where one is in fact forced to call into question their parentage. The first and most important casualty has been the connection to the concept of desire. All references to and considerations of desire are consciously excluded from discussion as either unnecessary or simply too messy. Assemblages are thereby reduced to mere apparatuses, which is precisely not what Deleuze and Guattari intended (they constantly caution us against taking a mechanistic view of things). The second casualty has been the multidimensional nature of the concept of the assemblage. This manifests itself in two ways: on the one hand, the assemblage is treated as a stand-alone concept, which it isn't, and on the other hand, the assemblage is treated as though it consists of only one kind of component, namely the machinic, which is similarly wrong-headed. As a consequence, much of what goes by the name of assemblage theory today is an emaciated and

innervated version of the full body of ideas and concepts Deleuze and Guattari bequeathed us. My aim in what follows is to restore to some of that lost conceptual vitality.

In this book, then, I do three things. I return to Deleuze and Guattari's concept of the assemblage. I distinguish their version of the assemblage from other versions that have emerged in the wake of their work. And I try to show how one might go about using their concept of the assemblage for practical applications in social and cultural research. If I spend time pointing out in a detailed way the shortcomings of several key iterations of assemblage theory, it is because they have become (in Deleuze and Guattari's own terms) the *image of the assemblage* and as a consequence they not only get in the way of a clear understanding of the original work, they also impede the necessary labour of experimenting with their ideas to see where they might take us by presenting us with a false picture of an already worked-out theory. Deleuze and Guattari themselves treat the assemblage as a provisional concept for which much 'working out' remained to be done. Unfortunately, neither lived long enough to complete the task, but I would argue that it is an unfinishable task because history itself is unfinished. In the years that followed the publication of *A Thousand Plateaus*, Deleuze quite deliberately returned to his own projects – to find himself again, he said – but Guattari continued to work on and develop the concept of the assemblage, giving us a far richer picture of the concept than can be found in their collaborative work alone (a fact that makes the refusal of erstwhile assemblage theorists like DeLanda to even read Guattari utterly mystifying).

I treat assemblage theory as an *incomplete project* that invites us to develop it further on the basis of a set of 'first principles'. The latter are developed throughout Deleuze and Guattari's work, but there is a coded summary of them in 'The Geology of Morals' chapter in *A*

Thousand Plateaus, which as it is obviously intended as a route map for the entire schizoanalytic project (of which assemblage theory is an essential component) makes a convenient starting place. If any single chapter deserves to be described as playful and poetic, it is this one – as such I offer a detailed reading of it in Chapter 1. ‘The Geology of Morals’ is far from easy to follow, not least because it is so playful and poetic, but if one reads it carefully it yields a small set of foundational propositions that one can use as a point of entry for the voyage into schizoanalysis (to borrow Virginia Woolf’s happy image for the process of reading a long-form text). Like Poe’s purloined letter, these propositions are hidden in plain sight and for that reason they can be very difficult to see. Not only that, one always has the feeling that someone – perhaps everyone – is seeing what you cannot, which can be discouraging and not a little bruising. However, we cannot all be like the perspicacious Monsieur Dupin and instantly see through every ruse, so we have to develop ways of stepping back and finding the right perspective to obtain a clear view. Ultimately, we simply need to trust in their advice that we will ‘be in a position to understand it later on’¹⁰ and resist the urge to seek what Jameson has appropriately called ‘the mischief of premature clarification.’¹¹

In the dialogue between Deleuze and Foucault ‘Intellectuals and Power’, Deleuze says a ‘theory is exactly like a box of tools. ... It must be useful. It must function.’¹² He goes on to say that like a new pair of glasses, an image he attributes to Proust, it should be used to see something outside and beyond its point of origin in a specific work. To read Proust is to see the whole of France’s Second Empire laid out on the dissecting table; similarly, to read Deleuze and Guattari is to see the whole of late capitalism laid out on the dissecting table. Doubtless this accounts for the notorious complexity of their work; its intellectual ambitions are literally boundless. Nothing less than a complete history of the present of desire is offered in the

two volumes of *Capitalism and Schizophrenia*. However, as I will show, in spite of its vast scope, one does not need to dumb down or modify Deleuze and Guattari's thinking in order to find in it a set of tools one can turn to one's own projects. The working parts of their methodology – the tools – are all hidden in plain view. To grasp them one has but to set aside one's presumptions as to what an assemblage should look like.

As Deleuze writes in *Difference and Repetition*, the problem of where to begin in philosophy has always been 'regarded as a very delicate problem, for beginning means eliminating all presuppositions'.¹³ In philosophy presuppositions come in two forms, objective and subjective, and it is all too easy to refuse the former only to fall back on the latter without even knowing it. Deleuze gives the example of Descartes who, because he did not want to define humans as rational animals which presupposes the concepts of rationality and animality (in an objective sense), instead proposed the model of the cogito in terms of a thinking subject. In doing so he claimed to have escaped the pitfall of objective presupposition; but it is clear, Deleuze says, that he has not escaped the subterranean danger of subjective presupposition because his definition of the cogito assumes 'that everybody knows, independently of concepts, what is meant by self, thinking, and being'.¹⁴ Descartes's 'I think' only appears to be a philosophical beginning because it has buried its presuppositions in the empirical realm of the self. In this way it fails to question what it necessarily presupposes. He taxes Hegel and Heidegger for making a similar style of error. How, then, are we to avoid making the same mistake? We must, he says, find the modesty to *not* know 'what everybody knows' and to *not* recognize 'what everybody is supposed to recognize'.¹⁵ Only then can we be without presuppositions. My task in this book is to try to bring to bear this way of thinking to the notion of the assemblage, which has become one of those concepts

like *différance*, ideology and performativity that everybody knows and everybody recognizes.

Inevitably, it seems, this brings us to the question that no one, not even the authors themselves, can avoid, namely how should we read Deleuze and Guattari? Their work is as playful and poetic as it is vast in scope and ambition. There are of course varying opinions as to the best way to proceed, but undoubtedly it is Brian Massumi's advice that one should approach *A Thousand Plateaus* as one does a record (a now outdated technological reference – the contemporary equivalent I suppose is a YouTube or Spotify playlist), which allows that one may skip sections, that has had the most traction. This advice no doubt comes as a relief to anyone struggling to make sense of a particular section, because it excuses the urge to jump ahead and skim over the parts that don't make immediate sense. Hence its popularity. The problem with Massumi's advice, though, is that it assumes either that one can come to grips with the central arguments of Deleuze and Guattari's work in an ad hoc fashion or that there is in fact no central argument that one needs to come to grips with and the work itself is ad hoc. While it is true that there is a high level of redundancy across the chapters such that if one misses something in one place one may pick it up elsewhere, there is also synthesis which demands that it be read in sequence. As Deleuze explains, the chapters of *A Thousand Plateaus* are 'like a set of split rings. You can fit any one of them into any other.'¹⁶ The trap for the unwary, however, is the way the concepts evolve and even change name and appearance as the book unfolds. If one misses this, then one risks treating concepts like the body without organs and the plane of immanence as distinct, when in actuality they are two faces of the same concept, which has several other faces as well.

If one were to use a musical analogy here for the way *A Thousand Plateaus* is composed it would be the notion of theme and variation,

whereby a musical motif is introduced and steadily varied throughout the composition until it becomes all but unrecognizable (the third movement of Beethoven's ninth symphony is one of the more well-known examples of this technique). Variation is an essential idea underpinning the entire schizoanalytic project, so this analogy is doubly appropriate. Variation can only be appreciated fully if one has a sense of the whole piece, which one simply cannot get by skipping sections or listening to it out of sequence. It is true that Deleuze and Guattari do say *A Thousand Plateaus* can be read in any order, but they also say the conclusion can only be read at the end, that is, when one has a solid grasp of the whole project. In other words, it doesn't matter how you get to an understanding of the whole just so long as you do. My sense though is that it is bad advice, reading it out sequence compounds the possibilities of misunderstanding by creating the false impression that the work isn't underpinned by a coherent logic, or building towards a composite understanding of the world. It is also true that Deleuze says that it is good to read a book as one listens to a record, but I would argue his purpose is to put the book on the same level as music, film and the cultural arts in general, not to suggest as Massumi implies that one should allow one's taste to dictate one's progress through the work.

This problem of how to approach *A Thousand Plateaus*, which Massumi rightly broaches, is raised to an even greater order of difficulty when one asks, where in fact does *A Thousand Plateaus* begin and end? Does it begin with *Anti-Oedipus*? Or does one need to go further back, and if so how far back? Does it include everything Deleuze wrote prior to meeting Guattari? Does it end with *What is Philosophy*? Does it also include everything Deleuze and Guattari wrote separately after *A Thousand Plateaus* was published? Should one read all their source materials as well? I have always thought that Deleuze and Guattari only ever had one project – the invention of

schizoanalysis – and that it began before they met and it continued after they stopped explicitly working together and it didn't stop with their deaths. It continued both because it couldn't be brought to completion by them (because there was always something new for them to consider) and because the conditions that prompted its invention, namely late capitalism, continue to obtain. Deleuze was already working on a version of schizoanalysis even before he met Guattari, just as Guattari was already working on a version of schizoanalysis before he met Deleuze. That is how and why they met. Deleuze wanted to talk to someone who worked with schizophrenics in order to test certain ideas he was developing about the language of schizophrenia and his former student suggested he get in touch with Guattari. Meanwhile Guattari had been working on some ideas about the machinic way schizophrenia worked using Deleuze's book *The Logic of Sense*, so when he was offered the chance to meet Deleuze he didn't hesitate.

Their relationship has been caricatured by people who should know better (i.e. Alain Badiou and Slavoj Žižek) as one in which the 'pure' philosopher Deleuze was politicized by the 'activist' Guattari. But aside from the underlying bad faith of such judgements, this caricature fails to pay attention to what they themselves say about their collaboration. In *Dialogues*, the book Deleuze wrote with Claire Parnet in between *Anti-Oedipus* and *A Thousand Plateaus* (this is how Deleuze himself puts it¹⁷), Deleuze tells a beautiful story about the way he worked with Guattari that makes it clear that it wasn't a simple case of one radicalizing the other. Deleuze has his own word for it, he calls it a pick-up procedure (he rejects the word 'method'). 'Félix was working on black holes; this astronomical idea fascinated him. The black hole is what captures you and does not let you get out. ... I was working, rather, on a white wall: what is a white wall, a screen, how do you plane down the wall and make a line of flight pass? We

had not brought the two ideas together, but we noticed that each was tending of its own accord towards the other, to produce something which, indeed, was neither in the one nor the other. For black holes on a white wall are in fact a face. ... Now it no longer resembles a face, it is rather the assemblage or the abstract machine which produces the face. Suddenly the problem bounces back and it is political: which societies and civilizations need this machine to function?’¹⁸ Every one of their concepts can be traced back to this singular question, which is not ‘how does it work?’ but ‘why is it happening?’ In order to answer this question they draw on the resources of every available intellectual system, which is what Deleuze means by pick-up method. It implies a convergence and collaboration between all forms of scholarly endeavour. In many ways it is this aspect of their work that has been the most influential, especially with scholars who do not read their work.

Although it draws on a disconcertingly heterogeneous range of material – here it helps to remember that they enlisted the aid of their students to compile this material over the course of seven years of teaching together – it is nonetheless a highly coherent body of work. And it is precisely the assemblage understood as a multidimensional concept that holds it all together. That the concept of the assemblage is the engine that drives Deleuze and Guattari’s entire critical project is signalled by Deleuze himself in three brief remarks made in the course of an interview with Catherine Clément following the publication of *A Thousand Plateaus*. Asked point-blank what holds *A Thousand Plateaus* together, Deleuze replies, ‘I think it is the idea of an assemblage (which replaces the idea of desiring machines).’¹⁹ As Deleuze explains in the discussion following his 1973 conference presentation published in English as ‘Five Propositions on Psychoanalysis,’ he and Guattari felt compelled to jettison the term ‘desiring-machine’ because they felt trapped by it – too many people

were using it, co-opting it and thereby domesticating it (one can only imagine how they'd feel about the word assemblage if they were alive today). Only a year after the publication of *Anti-Oedipus* Deleuze and Guattari were already concerned that 'desiring-machine' had lost its capacity to upset people.²⁰ But they were also moving on conceptually and in this sense the concept of the assemblage is not merely a new word for an old concept, it is a point of departure – it answers to a new problematic. As Deleuze explains in an interview published in *Libération* upon the publication of *A Thousand Plateaus*, the aim of the new book is to interrogate 'the circumstances in which things happen: in what situations, where and when does a particular thing happen, how does it happen, and so on?'²¹ The assemblage is intended to answer several types of question, 'how?', 'why?', 'when?' and not just a 'what?' question.²²

This leads me to the second remark I want to underscore because it goes to the heart of the entire schizoanalytic project. Deleuze tells Clément that he and Guattari 'are trying to substitute the idea of the assemblage for the idea of behaviour: whence the importance of ethology, and the analysis of animal assemblages, e.g. territorial assemblages.'²³ To which he adds an important and frequently overlooked clarification: the assemblage is first of all a problem of consistency and this is 'prior to the problem of behaviour.'²⁴ Ethology is a means of formulating a problem – the problem of desire – not the answer to the problem, nor the means to answering the problem. The same must be said for all of the scientific research Deleuze and Guattari draw on – they use it to formulate problems and create concepts, not as reference material.²⁵ While it is obvious Deleuze and Guattari drew a great deal of inspiration from the work of Uexküll, Tinbergen, Lorenz and others, it is equally clear that their work departs quite fundamentally from it as well. If we must connect it to ethology, then I think we need to see it as a reinvention of ethology rather than an extension of it, one that instigates a radical shift

of ground away from an idea of nature dominated by the involuntary promptings of our base instincts (however conceived). If we don't, then the risk is that we will reduce the assemblage to a biological system, or worse a set of instincts, that governs behaviour in a determinate manner, when precisely the opposite of that is what is at stake. To put it another way, it would not be much of a victory if we broke free of the iron grip of Freud's Oedipal models only to wind up in the similarly restrictive arms of Uexküll, for as interesting and as insightful as the latter is, his work offers only the most marginal of insights into the complexities of human behaviour in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries. And as is clear from the quotation at the head of this chapter, Deleuze and Guattari ultimately thought the notion of behaviour as it was formulated by ethology was flawed.²⁶

The third remark I want to focus on occurs a few lines after those cited above. Deleuze tells Clément that he and Guattari have themselves only begun to develop what he refers to as the 'general logic' of assemblages, and he expects that completing it will occupy them in the future. Sadly this was not to be, at least not in their work together. *What is Philosophy?* moves away from the central themes of *Anti-Oedipus* and *A Thousand Plateaus* and takes an inward turn to look at the constitution of philosophy itself. From the perspective of assemblage theory it adds very little except the important reminder that chaos is the essential ground zero of desire for both Deleuze and Guattari – it is what desire in its free state looks like, it is the source of all creativity and at the same time it threatens all forms with dissolution. Deleuze's own books, written in between *A Thousand Plateaus* and *What is Philosophy?*, similarly add little to the assemblage theory project. As I have argued elsewhere, Deleuze's two books on cinema are something of a missed opportunity in this respect because the one question they consistently avoid asking is precisely the schizoanalytic question of why would anyone want to watch this or that film?²⁷ By

contrast, Guattari's work in the years after *A Thousand Plateaus* is almost exclusively devoted to the development and expansion of the 'general logic' of assemblages. There are two points here that I want to underscore. First, Deleuze and Guattari conceived of assemblages as having a 'general logic'. This means we cannot start from single assemblages and work our way up – we have to start 'all at once' as one does with language (which is not to say assemblages are structured like a language). Second, the fact that Deleuze and Guattari saw that their project was incomplete means not only that we have an opportunity to complete it ourselves, but also that we need to be vigilant against premature attempts to bring the process to a close, which would only be possible if history itself had come to a standstill.

Asked if it wasn't a paradox for a work like *A Thousand Plateaus* to consider itself a system, Deleuze said while it had become commonplace to say knowledge systems have broken down and that knowledge is so fragmented that it was no longer possible to construct systems, it was completely false to think that systems thinking had lost its power. 'There are two problems with this idea: people can't imagine doing any serious work except on very restricted and specific little series; worse still, any broader approach is left to the spurious work of visionaries, with anyone saying whatever comes into their head.' Despite the various critiques of poststructuralism, postmodernism and deconstruction, systems have not lost their philosophical power according to Deleuze, because they have been rethought as open rather than closed systems. 'What I and Guattari call a rhizome' he says 'is precisely an open system.'²⁸ Deleuze and Guattari were not, as many people seem to think, opposed to the idea of something being expressible as a whole.²⁹ Indeed, the reality is without it neither the abstract machine nor the body without organs nor the assemblage would be thinkable as concepts. Deleuze and Guattari conceive of the concept of the whole, borrowing from Proust,

as ‘a product, produced as nothing more than a part alongside other parts, which it neither unifies nor totalizes, though it has an effect on these other parts because it establishes paths of communication between noncommunicating vessels, transverse unities between unities between elements that retain all their differences within their own particular boundaries.’³⁰ As they go onto say, the whole is poorly understood if it is treated as either the sum of its parts or an original totality; rather, as with Proust’s novel, it comes into being as the synthetic product of the work and at the same time sits above the work (superlinearity), simultaneously surveying every corner of its created universe and policing its boundaries.

This is perhaps the moment for me to say that my version of the assemblage owes nothing to the work of Manuel DeLanda, except perhaps as a useful reminder of why it is important to read Deleuze and Guattari carefully. DeLanda treats the assemblage as an aggregate, albeit a complex aggregate of the variety of an ecosystem. Nonetheless, for DeLanda the assemblage is an entity that grows in both scale and complexity as components are added. In his view, assemblages are ‘wholes whose properties emerge from the interactions between parts.’ He suggests they can be used to ‘model’ ‘entities’ such ‘interpersonal networks,’ ‘social justice movements,’ ‘cities’ and ‘nation-states.’³¹ Central to DeLanda’s thinking about assemblages is Deleuze’s idea (drawn from Hume) that relations are exterior to their terms. This enables DeLanda to offer an account of assemblages as ontologically ‘unique, singular, historically contingent, [and] individual’³² More particularly, though, DeLanda frames the assemblage as a new way of thinking about part-whole relations, essentially pitching it as a new kind of causality, that is, one that acts without conscious intention or purpose.

For example, during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries in Europe the authority structure of many organisations changed

from a form based on traditional legitimacy to one based on rational-legal bureaucratic procedures. The change affected not only government bureaucracies, but also hospitals, school and prisons. When studied in detail, however, no deliberate plan can be discerned, the change occurring through the slow replacement over two centuries of one set of daily routines by another. Although this replacement did involve decisions by individual persons ... the details of these decisions are in most cases causally redundant to explain the outcome.³³

There are a number of problems here, but I will focus on just three 'fatal flaws' in DeLanda's account: first, the assemblage does not constitute a part-whole relation; second, the assemblage is not the product of an accumulation of individual acts; and third, the assemblage does not change incrementally. To say that a bureaucratic structure of authority was constituted by and ultimately transformed by myriad individual acts says nothing but the obvious. One does not even need a concept to make this claim. This is history in the mode of one damn thing after another (as Arnold Toynbee famously put it). I will elaborate this briefly by turning to Deleuze and Guattari's account of the formation of the state in *Anti-Oedipus*. As will be immediately obvious, it follows a path that is diametrically opposite to the one mapped out by DeLanda. 'The State was not formed in progressive stages; it appears fully armed, a master stroke executed all at once; the primordial *Urstaat*, the eternal model of everything the State wants to be and desires.'³⁴ History is *in* the *Urstaat*, in its head, not the other way round: primitive society knew about the terrors of the state, Deleuze and Guattari argue (following Pierre Clastres), long before any actual states existed. Their rituals and customs, centred on the destruction of accumulated 'wealth' (i.e. stockpiles of seeds, weapons, furs and so on) so as to institute a socially binding debt-relation within the

‘tribe’ and between ‘tribes’, can be seen as staving off the formation of an actual state, which requires accumulated wealth (i.e. capital) to come into being. It is the idea of the state that concerns Deleuze and Guattari, not the practical matter of its coming into being.³⁵

DeLanda thus departs from Deleuze and Guattari in three crucial ways: first, he always proceeds from the concrete to the abstract, whereas Deleuze and Guattari (following Marx’s famous reversal of Hegel) tend to proceed from the abstract to the concrete – the state is first of all an idea, it only subsequently functions as a structure of authority; second, it seems he cannot countenance a purely immanent form of organization that isn’t somehow undergirded by the transcendent ‘real’, whereas Deleuze and Guattari say the exact opposite – the state can only function as it does to the extent that it can become immanent; and, third, he reverses the actual-virtual relation – he assumes that the concrete ‘bits and pieces’ are the actual – whereas for Deleuze and Guattari it is the structure of authority that is actual and the ‘bits and pieces’ that are virtual.³⁶ Marcus and Saka, indirectly following DeLanda, thus write that the assemblage ‘is a topological concept that designates the actualizations of the virtual causes or causal processes that are immanent in an open system of intensities that is under the influence of a force that is external (or heterogeneous) in relation to it’.³⁷ But this is precisely the wrong way round: *only the actual elements can be causal*. It is very clear in their discussion of the ‘actual factor’ in desiring-production that the actual is what is self-generated and therefore active in the unconscious, while the virtual is the imported and therefore inert or ‘dead’ element in the unconscious (e.g. they describe the Oedipal complex as virtual).³⁸

Lastly, I need to say something about the word ‘assemblage’ itself because there is a tendency apparent in much of ‘assemblage theory’ today to treat the word ‘assemblage’ in what might be called a ‘plain language’ fashion, as though the meaning of the concept is

self-evident from the choice of word. This can be seen in its application in the social sciences, where there is an emerging emphasis on the process of assembling itself.³⁹ This way of approaching the concept is only possible if one forgets or overlooks the fact that ‘assemblage’ is a translation of ‘agencement’. Perhaps because of its Francophone appearance – it is in fact a ‘loan’ word adopted from the French – it is assumed that it is the same word Deleuze and Guattari used and in the manner say of Derrida’s concept of ‘différance’ it has been left untranslated. At conferences one often hears presenters pronouncing ‘assemblage’ in an exaggeratedly French manner, suggesting that they think it is a French word, rather than a translation of a French word. By these subtle turns then the false idea that ‘assemblage’ is the original word and therefore the word one needs to explore in order to appreciate fully the concept’s range of meanings has become thoroughly entrenched as a ‘received idea’. Adding to the confusion, Deleuze and Guattari do occasionally use the French word ‘assemblage’ as well, but as John Phillips points out, never in the same technical or philosophical sense that they give to ‘agencement’.⁴⁰

Assemblage is Paul Patton and Paul Foss’s choice of translation for *agencement* which Brian Massumi picked up and used in his translation of *A Thousand Plateaus*. It has since become more or less the default translation, despite the fact that – as several people have pointed out⁴¹ – it has its problems.⁴² In my view, however, these problems are not resolved by altering the translation and using a different word, but rather by problematizing it and opening it up to a more complicated reading, one that is more consciously attentive to Deleuze and Guattari’s work. I would add that I think there is probably a strong case to be made for leaving it untranslated, as is increasingly the case with translations of critical theory concepts today, though that itself carries the risk of hypostatizing the term in a different way. Agencement derives from *agencer*, which according to *Le Roberts*

Collins means ‘to arrange, to lay out, or to piece together,’ whereas *assemblage* means ‘to join, to gather, to assemble.’⁴³ *Agencement*, as John Law has noted, encompasses a range of meanings that include ‘to arrange, to dispose, to fit up, to combine, to order.’⁴⁴ It could therefore just as appropriately be translated as *arrangement*, in the sense of a ‘working arrangement,’ provided it was kept clear that it described an ongoing process rather than a static situation.⁴⁵ It could also be thought in terms of a ‘musical arrangement,’ which is a way of adapting an abstract plan of music to a particular performer and performance. *Arrangement* is in many ways my preferred translation for these reasons, but it also has its problems, not least the fact it obscures the fact that ‘agency’ is at its core. So I wouldn’t say I disagree with Patton’s original choice, which like all translations has its problems but is very far from being wrong or inappropriate and I certainly think it is considerably better than several other choices that have also been tried.⁴⁶ But it is equally clear that it is a word that needs to be used with caution if we are not to fall into the trap of what I have called a plain-language conception of it.

Very quickly, then, I want to make two observations about the way Deleuze and Guattari use the word ‘*agencement*’ that foreshadows the trajectory I will follow in this book. To begin with, it is useful to note that *agencement* is Deleuze and Guattari’s own translation, or perhaps rearrangement would be a better word, of the German word *Komplex* (as in the ‘Oedipal complex’ or the ‘castration complex’). Although it is Guattari himself who defines the *assemblage* in this way in the various glossaries he has provided, the connection between Freud’s notion of complex and the concept of the *assemblage* has been almost completely ignored. If there is any word whose meaning one should explore as a way into *assemblage* theory then it is complex. According to Laplanche and Pontalis’s exhaustive account, there are three senses of the word complex in Freud’s writing: (1) ‘a relatively

stable arrangement of chains of association'; (2) 'a collection of personal characteristics – including the best integrated ones – which is organised to a greater or lesser degree, the emphasis here being on emotional reactions'; (3) 'a basic structure of interpersonal relationships and the way in which the individual finds and appropriates his place'.⁴⁷ Laplanche and Pontalis also note that there is an underlying tendency towards 'psychologism' inherent in the term. Not only does it imply that all individual behaviour is shaped by a latent, unchanging structure, it also allows that there is a complex for every conceivable psychological type. The key point I want to make here is that none of these ways of thinking about the complex actually requires that we give any consideration to a material object.

The second observation I want to offer is to note that in his comments on Man Ray's piece 'dancer/danger', Guattari (in his essay 'Balancing-Sheet Program for Desiring Machines', which was appended to the second edition of *Anti-Oedipus* and can therefore be read as a kind of bridging piece linking *Anti-Oedipus* to *A Thousand Plateaus*) observes that what is crucial about this assemblage is the fact that it doesn't work. He means this quite literally. The working parts, its cogs and wheels and so on, do not turn or intermesh with one another in a mechanical fashion. It is precisely for that reason, he argues, that it *works* as a piece of art.⁴⁸ It works by creating an association (i.e. a refrain) between the human dancer and the inhuman machine, and thereby brings them into a new kind of relation which he and Deleuze would later call the assemblage, but in their first works they called the desiring-machine. The only time they make a direct comparison between the unconscious and actual machines is when they compare it to the absurd machines of the Dadaists, surrealists, as well as the infernal machines imagined by Buster Keaton and Rube Goldberg.⁴⁹ And again, what is crucial is that these machines don't work. In other words, the obvious mechanical explanation of various machines is

precisely *not* what Deleuze and Guattari had in mind when they conceived of the concept of the assemblage and its forerunner, the desiring-machine.

As Deleuze and Guattari say, “Thinkers who do not renew the image of thought are not philosophers but functionaries who, enjoying a ready-made thought, are not even conscious of the problem and are unaware even of the efforts of those they claim to take as their models.”⁵⁰ Concepts should bring about a new way of seeing something and not simply fix a label to something we think we already know about. For Deleuze and Guattari the critical analytic question is always: Given a specific situation what kind of assemblage would be required to produce it?